

GroupTrack — Production Access Application

Where: Play Console → Test and release → Production → *Apply for production access* (both checks must show green: 12+ testers, 14 continuous days)

⚠ **Fill in the bracketed items before submitting.** Everything else is drawn from what GroupTrack actually did, not from a template. Google's reviewers are explicitly looking for specifics — named bugs, real changes, evidence the testing was genuine. Generic answers are the most common cause of rejection even when the 14 days are clean.

1) How did you recruit users for your closed test?

Both, and the mix was deliberate. I recruited from the off-road riding community directly — riders who run side-by-sides, UTVs, ATVs, dirt bikes and Jeeps, which is exactly who GroupTrack is built for — and supplemented with a paid testing service to reach the tester count and get coverage on devices I do not own.

Around **30 testers came from the riding community, recruited from March 2026 onward**, and **15 came from a paid testing service**.

The riders mattered more than the numbers. GroupTrack is used off-grid, on trails, often with no cell service, and the faults that matter only show up when someone is actually out there with it. Six months of riders using the app on real ground is where nearly all of the substantive feedback came from; the paid testers gave coverage on devices I do not own and kept the opt-in count stable.

2) How easy was it to recruit testers for your app?

Easy — *[or Moderate, your call]*

3) Describe the engagement you received from testers during your closed test

Engagement was hands-on and specific. Testers used the app on real rides rather than opening it to satisfy a counter, and the reports reflected that — problems that only appear in the field, on real terrain, with real trail data loaded for their state.

The most valuable report I received was also the least comfortable. A tester who rides regularly and uses Polaris Ride Command, Avenza, Gaia and onX wrote to say he had opened GroupTrack three times and could not work out how to use it — where those other apps had been intuitive enough that he never needed a manual. He described himself as closer to my average user than a twenty-something, and told me plainly that simplicity had to come before anything else.

He then set out what he expected instead: open to a map of where he is, move and resize it, and download that area for offline use in one action, with the map type and level of detail as options. Then record or build a route. Then put himself on the map under a name and invite others to follow. And a short description on every menu item explaining what it does.

That single message reshaped the release. It is the reason navigation moved from icons to text, and the reason route planning was rebuilt into one plainly worded step at a time rather than a checklist.

Other reports were narrower but equally actionable — a rider finding the route planner would not use a dirt road he rides every week, and testers reporting that searching the same area twice produced worse results the second time. Both turned out to be real defects and both are fixed.

△ *Do not include his phone number or full contact details in the submission — the substance is what matters, and a first name or "a tester" is enough.*

4) Provide a summary of the feedback you received. Include how you collected it.

Feedback came through direct communication with testers — email, messages and phone calls — and from crash reporting in the app. Reports have arrived steadily since the riding community joined in March 2026, not only during the closed-test window. Where a tester was stuck configuring the mesh radios their group rides with, I worked through it with them by phone.

One thing that surfaced repeatedly: **the documentation lagged the app**. Setup steps that had changed between builds were not written down, and testers hit them. That is why the release now bundles a QuickStart shown on first install and release notes shown after an update, so a rider is not relying on me being reachable.

The themes were:

Route planning was too complicated. The original flow presented a checklist of every step at once. Testers found it dense and hard to follow on a phone.

The planner would not use ground riders knew was rideable. Dirt roads they ride regularly were not available to the route builder.

Repeat searches in the same area returned worse results than the first search. Reported as inconsistency, and it turned out to be a real defect.

Testers could not reliably tell what the navigation icons meant. This came up often enough to be a pattern rather than a preference, and it fits the audience: the average GroupTrack rider is older than the typical app user.

The app allowed two map downloads to run at once, which its own documentation said was not permitted. A tester read the manual closely enough to spot the discrepancy, then found two separate routes into it — from the menu and from the drop-down.

Downloaded maps survived an uninstall, with no way to remove them from inside the app — a tester had to go into the file system by hand. He asked for a menu item to delete what had been downloaded.

The app crawled on one tester's budget device. Testing on hardware I do not own is exactly what I could not do alone.

[Any others — imports, map display, radio pairing, crashes.]

5) Who is the intended audience for your app?

Off-road riders — side-by-side, UTV, ATV, dirt bike and Jeep — who ride trails beyond cell coverage, usually in groups.

The core problem GroupTrack solves is that these riders lose contact with each other and with their maps exactly where it matters most. The app works entirely offline: maps, trail data and navigation are on the device, and group position sharing runs over mesh radio rather than a cell network.

6) Describe how your app provides value to the users.

GroupTrack does three things a rider cannot otherwise do off-grid:

Navigate without service. Map tiles and trail data are downloaded before the ride and work with no connection.

Keep a group together. Riders see each other's positions over mesh radio, so a convoy can spread out on a trail without losing anyone — the safety problem that motivated the app.

Plan a ride worth taking. The planner reads the trail network on the device and builds complete rides to a rider's distance and pace, then shows several to compare. Doing this by hand on a paper map or a generic mapping app takes hours.

7) How many installs do you expect in your first year?

1k – 10k

[If the form allows any comment, or if it fits in Q9:]

The intention is deliberate, controlled growth toward around 1,000 riders in the first year, not volume. That number is what I can support properly while the training material and support tooling mature.

The reason production access matters is distribution friction rather than scale. Today every tester has to be vetted and pre-registered by email before they can install, which is awkward for them and does not scale for me. A Play Store listing lets a rider find and install the app themselves.

8) What changes did you make based on what you learned during your closed test?

★ **This is the question that carries the application. Be concrete.**

Rebuilt the route planning flow. Testers found the original checklist dense and hard to work through on a phone. It is now one prompt at a time, sitting at the bottom of the screen so the map stays usable, with a plain-language explanation of each step and the ability to start over at any point.

Fixed a defect that made repeat searches unreliable. Testers reported that searching the same area twice gave worse results the second time. The cause was that the road network built for the first search was being reused in a modified state. Fixed, and verified by reproducing the original failure.

Added the ability to rebuild a ride from its saved settings. Riders wanted the alternatives they had not kept. Every route now records what produced it, and one button regenerates from those settings.

Made shared routes carry their description. A route sent to another rider now arrives with its written summary and the settings behind it, so the recipient can build their own variations.

Built proper download queues. A tester found he could start a second map download while one was already running, which the documentation said was not allowed. The finding showed the restriction was the wrong answer

rather than the behaviour being wrong — riders download several areas before a trip. Multiple queues are now supported and tuned, and the tester confirmed the fix.

Fixed application-not-responding errors on first launch. Testers reported ANRs after installing a new build. I traced it, shipped a release specifically for it (v2.4, 14 May 2026), and confirmed with the affected testers that it was resolved.

Excluded a device class that cannot run the app. A tester reported severe slowness. Investigating it on his device showed the cause: the handset advertises "4GB + 16GB" memory, but only about 2.9GB is real RAM visible to the system and the rest is swap on the flash storage chip, which is orders of magnitude slower. Under a full tile cache the app spills into swap and the device crawls. **I added that device class to the incompatible list in Play Console** rather than ship an experience that would look like a broken app to anyone who bought one.

Added map deletion, and let riders choose what goes. A tester found that downloaded maps survived an uninstall and had to be removed through the file system. The first version I proposed deleted everything at once — testers pushed back, saying they wanted to choose which areas to remove. It now works the same way installing does: draw the area, delete it. **The design came from the testers, not from me.**

Replaced icon-based navigation with text. Testers could not reliably identify what the icons meant. The average rider using GroupTrack is older than the typical app user, and they are reading the screen on a trail — often in bright sun, often wearing gloves. Labelled buttons removed the guesswork, and this is visible in the current screenshots.

Clearer guidance where testers got stuck — telling riders to include the state when searching for an area, because the same place name exists in many states and landing in the wrong one is not obvious.

[Add anything else — crash fixes, import fixes, map display.]

9) How did you decide your app is ready for production?

The features a rider needs on a trail are complete and have been used on real rides: offline maps, trail data by state, group position sharing over mesh radio, and route planning. The faults testers found have been fixed and the fixes verified on device, not just in code.

It is also stable in the way that matters for this app — it runs for hours with the screen on, recording a track, with no network. That is the condition it is used in.

The stability problems testers found were addressed directly rather than deferred: the application-not-responding errors reported in May were traced and fixed in a release issued for that purpose, and where a device class genuinely could not run the app I excluded it rather than let a rider discover it on a trail.

I am also not asking for production access in order to scale quickly. The plan is controlled growth to roughly 1,000 riders over the first year, so that quality, training material and support keep pace. Remote support has been a large part of how problems were diagnosed during testing, and that only works at a size I can actually service.

[If you have crash-free numbers from Play Console, quote them here — reviewers respond well to a figure.]

10) What did you do differently this time?

This is my first application for production access. What I would point to is what came before it.

Before creating a closed test on Play at all, I ran **six months of testing with around 30 experienced side-by-side riders**, distributing builds directly. These are not casual testers: several have working knowledge of search-and-rescue applications, Meshtastic radio deployment, and off-road navigation requirements, and all of them use the

established commercial apps in this category — Polaris Ride Command, Avenza, Gaia and onX — so their comparisons are informed.

They have been engaged through the design and implementation of the software rather than handed a finished build to try. The changes listed above came out of that: the navigation was rewritten, map deletion was designed the way they asked for rather than the way I proposed, a device class was excluded, and the entire route planning flow was rebuilt after a tester told me plainly he had opened the app three times and could not use it.

The Play closed test was the formal step at the end of that process, not the start of it.

⚠ Before you submit

Check both green lights on the production access page. Applying early is rejected outright and you resubmit after the full period.

The 14 days must be continuous and testers must have stayed opted in.

Review usually takes 7 days or less.

⚠ **Do not paste the vendor's template.** Several of its answers describe an app that is not GroupTrack — a "Rate Your App" button and ASO optimisation were never your closed-test findings, and a reviewer comparing your answers to your actual release history will see that.